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Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions Theory



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Definition

Hofstede's cultural dimensions theory refers to cross-cultural differences in organizational and national culture defined as "the collective programming of the mind that distinguishes the members of one group or category of people from others" (Hofstede, 2011, p. 3). The current version of the Hofstede-Minkov model is composed of six dimensions: individualism-collectivism, power distance, uncertainty avoidance, masculinity-femininity, long-term versus short-term orientation, and indulgence-restraint. Four initial dimensions are "classical."

The Overview

Geert Hofstede (1928–2020), social psychologist and engineer, introduced his model of cultural dimensions in two seminal works: *Culture Consequences* (1980) and *Culture and Organizations: Programming of the Mind* (1991). Originally, Hofstede's model was based on questionnaires collected between years 1968 and 1972 from the 116,000 workers of the IBM company in its 50 different national branches. Aggregated data were then analyzed using exploratory factorial analysis (Hofstede, 2011). Given that the IBM is an international company, such studies aimed to detect possible cross-cultural differences in organizational culture. As such, the main areas of research were targeted toward interpersonal relations in the work context, work-life balance, or relationships between subordinates and managers. Given the specificity of the IBM company, the participants were mostly men. Initially, the Hofstede's work was aimed to explain the cross-cultural differences in the work context; later the model was extended to more global national culture. Hofstede assumed that the "software of the mind" is shaped during socialization process, and this socialization process is influenced by the culture in which the individual lives. Cultural dimensions are an attempt to provide a basis for analyzing cross-cultural differences. Initially, Hofstede (1980) proposed only four dimensions. This model was later supplemented by Michael Bond and colleagues (Chinese Cultural Connections, 1987) and reformulated and supplemented by Michael Minkov (Hofstede et al., 2010). Therefore, the final model comprises six dimensions (Hofstede, 2011). The most recent work by Michael Minkov and Anneli Kaasa (2022) is an attempt to propose methodological and conceptual refinement of the work initialized by Geert Hofstede. Therefore, the current entry is aimed to provide basic information on classical model of

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Geert Hofstede, presents an evolution of this model in the follow-up works of Hofstede and his collaborators, and summarizes the strengths and the criticism raised around this undoubtedly famous attempt of classification of the cultural differences from psychological perspective.

Cultural Dimensions and Their Consequences

Hofstede coined the term "software of the mind" to describe a way how we communicate with others as a result of rising in a certain group. The content of the "software" is shaped upon socialization, yet this process was not specified by Hofstede, who was interested much more in classification of differences between cultural "software," as something which is shared by a group, but is not a feature of individual. Therefore, the unit of analysis in the Hofstede's model is nation (Hofstede, 1991, 2011). The work of Hofstede was heavily inspired by sociological and anthropological analyses of culture, especially by Inkeles and Levinson (1969). They understood "national character" as reflected in the most common pattern of personality within national group, and they proposed three "standard analytic issues" as features of national character, which were next operationalized by Hofstede as cultural dimensions (see Hofstede, 2011).

The final version of the Hofstede model comprises dimensions of power distance, individualism-collectivism, masculinity-femininity, uncertainty avoidance, long−/short-term orientation, and indulgence-restraint (Hofstede et al., 2010; Hofstede, 2011); original four dimensions were supplemented by two others as a result of consultations with Michael Bond and Michael Minkov (Hofstede, 2011).

Individualism-Collectivism

This dimension refers to the integration between individual and primary groups (Hofstede, 2011). Individualism refers to extend to which people feel independent and focused on themselves and close family members and define themselves in terms of "I." Individualism is reflected in higher divorce rate, separation of children from family home, lower fertility, and more informal relationships (Hofstede, 2011; Minkov & Kaasa, 2022). Collectivism means stronger preference for tightly knit social bonds with the members of own community. Therefore, people living in collectivistic societies are more dependent on others in their decisions and actions, they expect others to care about them, and they reciprocate by strong in-group loyalty (Hofstede, 2011). They define themselves in terms of "we." Individualism is positively related to democracy and national income. Individualism index is higher in more affluent and Western countries, while collectivism index is greater in less affluent and Eastern countries (Hofstede et al., 2010).

Power Distance

This dimension refers to what extend the low-status people expect and accept the fact that the power is unequally distributed within the society or organization. Power distance reflects the level of stress in a society once this society faced the unknown future (Hofstede, 2011). Higher power distance means greater acceptance of social and economic inequalities, which results in accepting social order as natural and not requiring further justification. Lower power distance means that people are motivated to deal with inequalities and demand justification for any kind of unequal power distribution. People living in the societies with high power distance are reluctant to express opinions different from their authorities or bosses, belief that these on top of the power hierarchy make autocratic decisions, and accept this reality. Greater power distance is related negatively to national income, democracy levels, and respecting human rights, and it is positively related to political violence, gerontocracy, and corruption (Hofstede, 2011). Power distance is higher in East European, Latin, Asian, and African countries and lower in Germanic and English-speaking countries (Hofstede et al., 2010).

Uncertainty Avoidance

This dimension refers to dealing with uncertainty and ambiguity. High uncertainty avoidance means preference for structured situations; therefore it

results in strong regulation of behavioral codes, laws, and rules, as well as in accepting dogmatism, that is, a belief in absolute truth (Hofstede, 2011). Higher uncertainty avoidance is accompanied by greater stress, lower subjective well-being, and intolerance for deviant people or ideas; in religious and academic life, it is accompanied by absolutism and not challenging established ideas and behaviors. Lower uncertainty avoidance is accompanied by greater subjective well-being, lower stress, greater tolerance for deviant people or ideas, greater relativism, and fewer regulations. The correlates of this dimension are unclear and not evidenced (Minkov & Kaasa, 2022). Greater uncertainty avoidance is found higher in Eastern and Central European, Latin American, Japan, and German-speaking countries and lower in English-speaking, Nordic, and Chinese culture countries (Hofstede et al., 2010).

Masculinity Versus Femininity

This dimension reflects the division of emotional roles between women and men (Hofstede, 2011). It is the most conceptually problematic dimension, as it refers to the diversity versus similarity of gender roles within the society and to primary goals as more assertive (masculine) or more socially oriented (feminine). Masculine cultures are related to greater "dimorphism," that is, men are more assertive and less similar to women, yet women from these cultures also tend to be more assertive as compared to women living in feminine societies. In feminine cultures both men and women are more similar to each other and more oriented toward modest and social care values. In the organizational settings, masculine culture is manifested in stronger focus on work as challenging, getting praise for professional achievements and greater opportunity for promotion and getting higher salaries and what is observed among both sexes. In the feminine societies, people of both sexes strive for socially oriented goals, like social care, good relations in the work place, security at workplace, or work-life balance (Hofstede, 2011). This dimension reflects gender inequality, so that in the masculine cultures men dominate in public and private life, while feminine cultures are egalitarian, respecting women rights (Hofstede, 2011). Masculinity index is high in Japan, German-speaking countries, or some Latin American countries (e.g., Mexico) and low in Scandinavian countries and the Netherlands (Hofstede et al., 2010).

Long-Term Versus Short-Term Orientation

This dimension was proposed by Michael Bond and Chinese scholars (1987), as reflecting choice of focus for people's efforts, as located in the present, in the future, or in the past (Hofstede, 2011). Long-term orientation is expressed in valuing perseverance and thrift, ordering relationships by status, and experiencing "shame." Short-term orientation is expressed in valuing the past or presence; focus on tradition, consumption, and generosity; and focus on "face saving" and high national pride (Hofstede, 2011). This dimension was next relabeled (Hofstede et al., 2010; Minkov & Kaasa, 2022), so it is also known as monumentalism (former short-term orientation) and flexhumility or flexibility (former long-term orientation), being operationalized as putting stress on savings versus on generosity, which corresponds with the gratification delay. In the recent work, Minkov and Kaasa (2022) refined this dimension on the basis of extensive analysis of the World Values Survey data, proposing new operationalization as limited to attitudes toward investment and thrift (flexibility) versus sharing resources with others by generosity and immediate consumption of resources (monumentalism). Greater long-term orientation is correlated with greater economic growth (Hofstede et al., 2010).

Indulgence Versus Restraint

This dimension was proposed by Michael Minkov (Hofstede et al., 2010). It is reflected in attitudes toward gratification or controlling human needs related to enjoying life (Hofstede, 2011). Indulgence characterizes cultures allowing for free gratification of needs and expressing joy, while restraint cultures regulate gratification of needs by using strict control means (Hofstede et al., 2010; Hofstede, 2011). Indulgent societies are characterized by lower valuing respecting order, more

sport activity, greater happiness, and expressing positive emotions, but also – in the countries which are both affluent and indulgent, there are more obese people and more birthrates. Restraint societies are characterized by the opposite. This dimension gained less popularity than the remaining ones, and in more recent studies, it occurred to be not essential in classifying cultures (Minkov & Kaasa, 2022).

Conclusions

The Hofstede cultural dimensions model gained high traction, yet it gained also serious criticism, mostly because of methodological concerns (Minkov & Kaasa, 2022; Williamson, 2002). These critical points could be summarized by poor face validity, too high correlation between dimensions, and biased samples with overrepresentation of men originating from specific company, that is, IBM (Minkov & Kaasa, 2022; Williamson, 2002). Therefore, to address these issues, Hofstede and his collaborators used World Values Survey data to refine operationalization of cultural dimensions (Hofstede et al., 2010). Minkov and Kaasa's (2022) work suggest that, out of six dimensions, only two are both meaningful and replicated in the WVS, that is, individualism-collectivism and flexibility-monumentalism. These dimensions are based on indexes emerged in principal component analysis (Minkov & Kaasa, 2022) and were validated by correlating them with objective data, like GDP or murder rate (Hofstede, 2011; Minkov & Kaasa, 2022), still being suitable only for country-level analyses. Overall, the Hofstede's model remains influential for the next generations of social scientists interested in cross-cultural differences in work and everyday life settings. This model inspired also GLOBE project (House et al., 2004).

Cross-References

- ▶ Collectivistic Cultures
- ▶ Individualistic Cultures

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